ON FOREIGN POLICY, INDIA WANTS CONTINUITY

WHILE THE FTA IS PROGRESSING SATISFACTORILY, ISSUES RELATED TO MIGRATION AND MOBILITY NEED TO BE RESOLVED EARLY AND TO MUTUAL SATISFACTION



By **GAITRI ISSAR KUMAR**

Unity and Stability. Rishi Sunak, the newly appointed prime minister of the United Kingdom, has announced that these will be his first and foremost goals. As Leader of the Conservative Party, Sunak has vowed to unite his party as he prepares to lead it to the polls in 2024. Unity of the four regions of the UK would be a key priority for an incoming PM, given that Scotland has prominently echoed the call by the Labour Party for an early general election and the unresolved issues related to the Northern Ireland Protocol are burning again. Forging unity among the people of the UK, who are divided on issues as never before, is an obvious aspiration for him too.

It is a foregone conclusion that as prime minister, Sunak will accord the highest priority to domestic matters. Chief among these is the economy: low growth, spiralling inflation, surging prices, labour shortages, mounting debt, the cost-of-living crisis and the need to cap, or at least control, the cost of household energy. Though the population is apprehensive about another round of austerity measures, Sunak has assured them of a 'compassionate' approach. As Chancellor of the Exchequer, Sunak had, during the peak of the Covid crisis, rolled out furloughs and schemes to support the vulnerable, which had been well received. It may be anticipated that as premier, he will hit the ground running, but take the people along as he approaches the various challenges with determination.

What does his ascension mean for the UK's foreign relations, particularly for India? The answer to this will be clear when his government declares its foreign policy imperatives and India-UK strategy. The UK foreign secretary has, on day one of the new government, reached out to external affairs minister S. Jaishankar. That is a good sign. One can safely anticipate that there will be no dramatic departure from the once-in-a-generation report presented by the Boris Johnson government after its integrated review of the UK's security, defence, development and foreign policy in March 2021. The document sets UK's national security and foreign policy objectives till 2025, envisioning a global Britain that would play a leading role on the world stage, particularly in addressing issues like healthcare, defence and security, climate change and sustainable development. In these areas, India and the UK have had a long-standing and successful partnership. As PM, Sunak can be expected to give strong leadership in finetuning the UK's foreign policy that has been diverted, over the last eight months, by the situation in Ukraine.

An Indian-origin PM of the UK is a watershed moment for the Indian diaspora—and world leaders have not failed to recognise its significance. However, as one commentator pointed out, Sunak is there because of the tremendous respect that he commands in his party.

With regard to ties with India, it would be desirable that 'continuity' be added to Sunak's guiding principles—particularly while working towards the objectives jointly identified by India and the UK in the Road Map to 2030. Launched in May 2021, it was the first such 10-year commitment made by the UK with any foreign government. The initiatives and cooperation covered in this document range from space and science, advanced technology and education to healthcare, trade, defence and security, culture, sustainable development and beyond.

As Chancellor, Sunak joined finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman in issuing a joint statement in September 2021 that detailed a forward-looking strategy to bring a new impetus to bilateral cooperation on the economic, trade and financial sectors. Sunak had supported the goal of doubling India-UK trade by 2030, currently $30 billion, and for the early conclusion of a Free Trade Agreement (FTA).

For the first time, the anomaly of social security payment by Indian workers deployed in the UK—without accruing the benefits of their contribution—was brought on the agenda of the ministers, as also on the FTA grid. For the landmark trade treaty, negotiations have been progressing satisfactorily. A few challenging chapters in the proposed FTA remain to be